En la mesa: quedarse · dejar · llevarse

Keep it, leave it, take it away · restaurant Spanish

The short answer: The confusion almost always comes from one thing: who the subject of the verb is. In English the plate is the subject ("it can stay"). In Spanish you usually say it from your point of view ("I keep it": me lo quedo) or you tell the waiter what to do ("leave it": déjalo). Se queda is correct for "it stays"; me quedo never means "it stays", it means "I'm staying". Below: the subject rule, exactly what to reply when the waiter hovers over your plate, every table verb you will hear in Spain, and the pronoun combinations you will actually say.

01 The subject rule (why me quedo is not "it stays")

Quedarse literally means "to stay". The ending tells you WHO stays. Me quedo = I stay. Se queda = he, she or it stays. So "the plate stays" is el plato se queda, and "the plates stay" is los platos se quedan. When Spanish wants to say "I keep it", it says "I stay with it": me quedo con el plato, or shorter, me lo quedo. The subject is still you, not the plate. That is the line that trips people up: me lo quedo is about you keeping it, not about the plate staying.

Spanish	Who is the subject?	English
Me quedo.	yo	I'm staying.
Se queda.	it (el plato, el vaso, eso)	It stays.
Se quedan.	they (los platos, las copas)	They stay.
Me quedo con el plato.	yo	I'll keep the plate.
Me lo quedo.	yo (lo = the thing)	I'll keep it.
Me los quedo.	yo (los = the plates)	I'll keep them.
Que se quede.	it (subjunctive)	Let it stay. / Leave it there.

Note: Both work for your plate situation: "Se queda, gracias" (it stays) and "Me lo quedo" (I'll keep it) are correct. They just look at it from different sides. Neither is what a Spaniard would most often say though: see section 2.

Ejemplo	English
- ¿Te retiro el vaso? - No, se queda, que todavía tengo vino.	- Shall I take your glass? - No, it's staying, I've still got wine.
- ¿Te retiro el plato? - No, me lo quedo, que quiero mojar pan.	- Shall I take your plate? - No, I'll keep it, I want to mop up the sauce.

02 Replying when the waiter wants to clear

The most natural reply is an instruction to the waiter, so the verb is dejar (leave it) or llevarse (take it away), in the imperative. Waiters in Valencia almost always use tú with you; if you hear usted, use the usted forms in brackets.

You want to say	Natural Spanish	Notes
Yes, take it	**Sí, llévatelo. / Sí, puedes llevártelo.**	(usted: lléveselo) · plural: llévatelos

You want to say	Natural Spanish	Notes
Yes, clear it all	**Sí, sí, retíralo todo.**	retirar = to clear (the waiter's own word)
No, leave it	**No, déjalo, gracias.**	(usted: déjelo) · plural: déjalos
Leave it, I'm still eating	**Déjalo, que todavía estoy.**	"todavía estoy" = I'm still on it
I haven't finished	**Aún no he terminado.**	or: todavía no he acabado
Leave me the bread	**Déjame el pan.**	dejar + me = leave it for me
Take the plate, leave the glass	**Llévate el plato, pero déjame la copa.**	mix both verbs freely
It can stay	**Puede quedarse. / Se puede quedar.**	correct, slightly less common than déjalo
I'll keep it	**Me lo quedo. / Me quedo con la carta.**	about you keeping it (menu, glass, bread)

Trap: Do not answer with "me quedo" on its own. That means "I'm staying" (as in, not leaving the restaurant). And "lo quedo" without me is not Spanish: keeping is always quedarse, so me lo quedo, te lo quedas, se lo queda.

Ejemplo	English
- ¿Habéis terminado? - Yo sí, llévatelo. Ella todavía está, déjaselo.	- Have you finished? - I have, take it. She's still eating, leave hers.
- ¿Os retiro esto? - Sí, gracias, pero déjanos el pan.	- Shall I clear this? - Yes thanks, but leave us the bread.

03 Dejar: every job it does at the table

Phrase	English	When you'll hear or say it
Déjalo / déjalos	Leave it / them	telling the waiter not to clear
Te dejo la carta.	I'll leave the menu with you.	waiter, after taking drinks
Te lo dejo aquí.	I'll leave it here for you.	waiter putting the card machine or bill down
Me he dejado el móvil.	I've left my phone behind.	dejarse = to leave something by accident
Dejar propina	To leave a tip	Dejamos un par de euros.
Lo ha dejado casi todo.	He left almost all of it.	food left on the plate
Déjame ver / déjame pagar	Let me see / let me pay	dejar + infinitive = to let
Déjalo, que invito yo.	Don't worry, it's on me.	the fight over the bill

Note: Dejar is about the thing staying while someone moves away from it. Use it whenever you are telling someone to leave something where it is.

Ejemplo	English
Perdona, creo que me he dejado la chaqueta en la silla.	Sorry, I think I've left my jacket on the chair.
No, no, déjalo, que hoy invito yo.	No, no, leave it, today's on me.

04 Llevar, llevarse, traer: direction matters

Llevar is to take something to somewhere. Llevarse adds "away from here": the thing leaves with the person. Traer is to bring it towards where the speaker is. Para llevar is the Spanish "to take away".

Verb	Meaning	Example
llevarse	take away (it leaves here)	¿Me lo llevo? = Shall I take it away?
llevarse	take (buying, in a shop)	Me lo llevo. = I'll take it.
llevar	take to / carry somewhere	Llevo esto a la mesa cuatro. (waiter, on the way)
traer	bring (to here)	¿Me traes la cuenta? · Ahora te lo traigo.
para llevar	to take away	¿Para tomar aquí o para llevar?
poner para llevar	box it up	¿Me lo pones para llevar? · ¿Me lo pones en un táper?

Trap: "¿Le llevo los platos?" means "Shall I carry the plates over to you?", not "shall I take them away". A waiter clearing says ¿Me los llevo?, ¿Te lo retiro? or ¿Te quito esto? The me in me los llevo is what makes it "away".

Ejemplo	English
Nos ha sobrado mucho. ¿Nos lo pones para llevar?	We've got loads left. Could you box it up for us?
Cuando puedas, ¿nos traes la cuenta?	When you get a sec, could you bring us the bill?

05 Other verbs you will hear from the waiter

Verb	What you hear	What it means
poner	¿Qué os pongo?	What can I get you?
tomar	¿Qué vais a tomar? · ¿Para tomar aquí?	What are you having? · Eating in?
apetecer	¿Os apetece algún postre?	Fancy a dessert?
retirar	¿Os retiro los platos?	Shall I clear your plates?
quitar	¿Te quito esto?	Shall I take this away?
recoger	Ahora os recojo la mesa.	I'll clear the table in a sec.
terminar / acabar	¿Habéis terminado? · ¿Ya está?	Finished? · All done?
quedar (no se)	No nos queda tarta. · ¿Queda pan?	We've no cake left. · Is there any bread left?
sobrar	Ha sobrado mucho.	There's lots left over.
cobrar	¿Me cobras? · ¿Te cobro ya?	Can I pay? · Shall I take payment now?
invitar	Os invita la casa.	It's on the house.
estar	¿Estaba todo bien?	Was everything OK?

Note: Quedar without se is the other big one: me queda, nos queda, no queda = there is (none) left. "No queda" from a waiter means they have run out.

Ejemplo	English
- ¿Te cobro ya? - Sí, ¿se puede con tarjeta?	- Shall I take payment now? - Yes, can I pay by card?

Ejemplo	English
Lo siento, de eso ya no nos queda.	Sorry, we've run out of that.

06 Quedarse vs quedar: the five meanings

Form	Meaning	Example
quedarse	to stay (in a place)	Me quedo un rato más. = I'm staying a bit longer.
quedarse con / quedárselo	to keep	Quédate con el cambio. · Me lo quedo.
quedarse + adj / sin	to end up (a state)	Me he quedado lleno. = I'm stuffed. · Nos quedamos sin mesa.
quedar	to be left / remain	No queda paella. · Nos quedan dos cervezas.
quedar con alguien	to meet up with	He quedado con unos amigos para cenar.

Ejemplo	English
Quedaos un rato más, que no queda nadie y nos quedamos con la terraza para nosotros.	Stay a bit longer, there's nobody left and we'll have the terrace to ourselves.

07 Pronouns you will actually say

Object pronouns stick onto the end of a command (with an accent to keep the stress) and go in front of a normal verb. Me/te/nos come first, then lo/la/los/las.

Spanish	Built from	English
Llévatelo.	lleva + te + lo	Take it away.
Llévatelos.	lleva + te + los	Take them away.
Déjamelo.	deja + me + lo	Leave it for me.
Déjaselo.	deja + se (le) + lo	Leave it for her / him.
Me lo quedo.	me + lo + quedo	I'll keep it.
Quédatelo.	queda + te + lo	Keep it. (to a friend)
¿Me lo pones para llevar?	me + lo + pones	Can you box it up for me?

Ejemplo	English
¿La chaqueta? Quédatela, a ti te queda mejor.	The jacket? Keep it, it suits you better.

08 Full scene: end of a meal in Valencia

Ejemplo	English
- ¿Qué tal todo? ¿Os retiro los platos?	- How was everything? Shall I clear your plates?
- Sí, llévatelos, gracias. Pero déjanos el pan, que queda salsa.	- Yes, take them, thanks. But leave us the bread, there's still sauce.
- Claro. ¿Os apetece algún postre o un café?	- Sure. Fancy any dessert or a coffee?

Ejemplo	English
- ¿Queda tarta de queso? - Uy, no, lo siento, no nos queda.	- Is there any cheesecake left? - Oh, no, sorry, we've run out.
- Pues dos cortados. Y cuando puedas, nos cobras.	- Two cortados then. And whenever you can, we'll pay.
- Ha sobrado arroz, ¿nos lo pones para llevar?	- There's rice left over, could you box it up for us?
- Déjalo, que invito yo. Y quédese con el cambio.	- (to your friend) Leave it, I'm paying. (to the waiter) And keep the change.

09 Chuleta rápida: which verb?

Situation	Say	Why
Telling the waiter to leave it	**Déjalo.**	you give an instruction, dejar = leave
Telling the waiter to take it	**Llévatelo. / Retíralo.**	llevarse = it goes away
Describing the thing staying	**Se queda. / Se quedan.**	the thing is the subject
You are keeping it	**Me lo quedo.**	you are the subject: quedarse con
You are staying	**Me quedo.**	you are the subject: no object
They have run out	**No queda.**	quedar without se